

SENDKIT DOCS

SEGs explained (and the SEG setting)

A secure email gateway (SEG) is a filtering layer that big companies put in front of their normal email system, specifically to catch cold email before it reaches an employee's inbox. Proofpoint, Barracuda, Mimecast, and Microsoft Defender are the common ones.

What a SEG actually does

A regular inbox provider like Gmail or Outlook filters spam using its own reputation and content signals. A SEG sits in front of that, added by the company's IT or security team, and applies its own separate, usually stricter, filtering rules. It exists to protect employees from phishing and unwanted outreach, and cold email gets caught in that net whether or not it is malicious.

If a lead's company uses one of these gateways, your email has to pass through it before the recipient's actual inbox provider ever evaluates it. That is an extra, harder filter most senders do not realize exists until their reply rate to certain companies mysteriously goes quiet.

Why sending into SEGs burns domains

SEGs are aggressive by design, and they are shared infrastructure across every company using that vendor. Get flagged by Proofpoint at one company, and it can affect how Proofpoint treats your domain at other companies using the same vendor. Cold email into SEG-protected addresses carries a meaningfully higher chance of tripping a spam flag than email into a normal Gmail or Outlook inbox, and that flag can cost you domain reputation you are also relying on for every other lead on your list.

THE TRADE

SEG-protected leads carry the highest risk-to-reward ratio in your entire list. The upside of reaching one enterprise employee rarely justifies the downside of risking your domain's reputation with everyone else.

The rule: skip unless enterprise is your actual ICP

Enterprise is a small slice

Deprioritize SEG-protected leads rather than excluding your whole strategy around them. Prioritize the rest of your list instead.

Enterprise is your actual ICP

You have to reach those addresses anyway, since that is where your buyers are. Expect a lower landing rate on those specific sends and budget your domain reputation accordingly, ideally on dedicated infrastructure that isolates the risk.

WHY THIS WORKS ON SENDKIT

SendKit detects and flags Proofpoint, Barracuda, Mimecast, and Microsoft Defender addresses automatically, free on every plan, so you can skip or deprioritize them before you ever risk a send.

Turn on SEG detection for your enterprise lists

If enterprise accounts sit anywhere in your list, turn on SEG detection so you can flag or deprioritize gateway-protected addresses before you send.

[Check your list for SEGs](#)